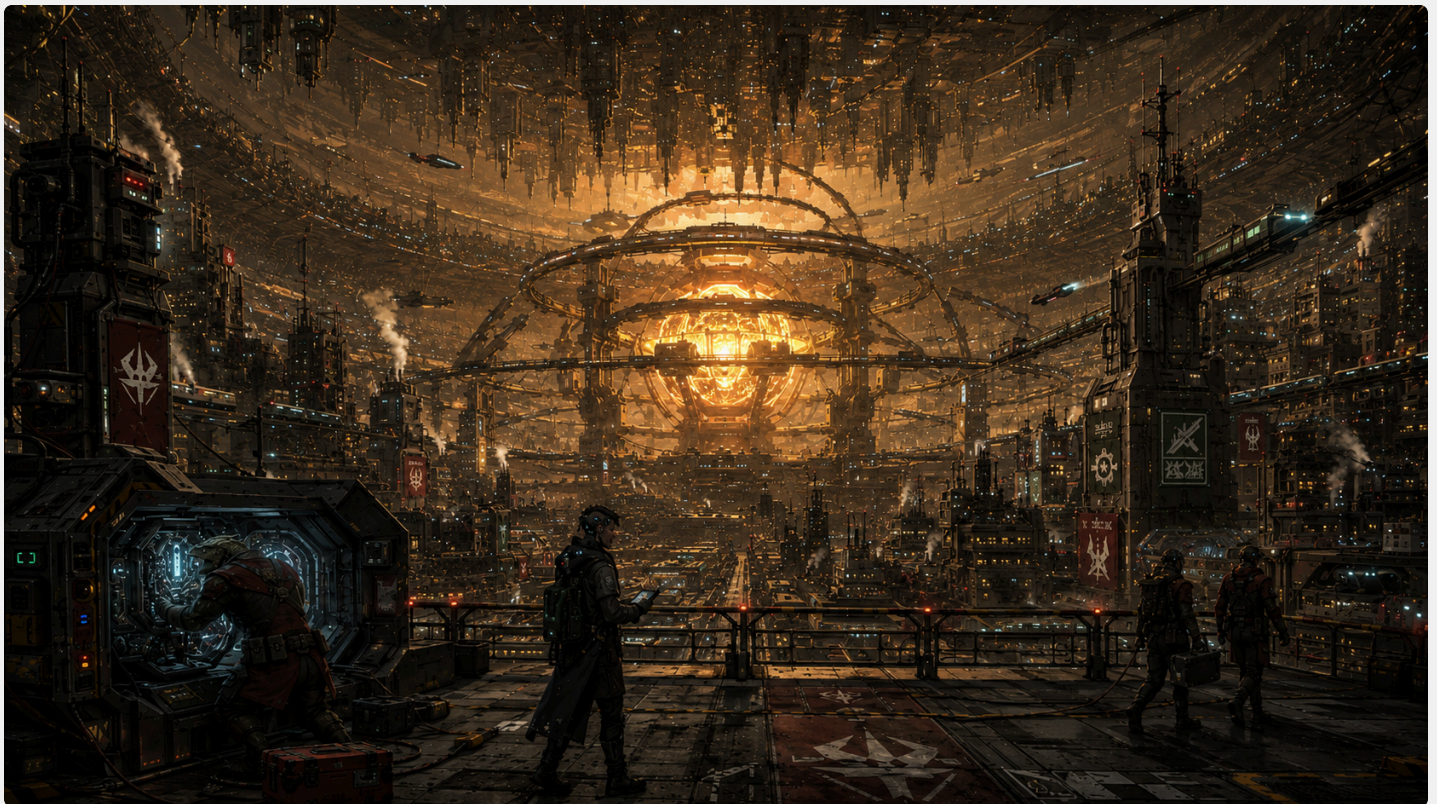


ZAKARON

Summary

Zakaron, the **Inverted Arsenal**, is the ancestral world of the **Madrosarai** and **Vesk**. The Rupture Wars destroyed its surface and much of the original planet. Its survivors rebuilt within a reinforced remnant, arranging their city around a central cavity. Artificial gravity holds residents against the inside of the shell, with the opposite districts hanging upside down overhead. A contained fragment of the old core, the **Sunlock**, lights the city.

Kharosai houses 3.1 billion people across its inward-facing skyline and the densely inhabited rock behind it. Zakaron leads the **Settled Systems** in military technology and cybernetics. It remains independent of **Erbium Industries LLC**, though its fleets depend on access to refined erbium and recognized Drift infrastructure.



The Inverted Arsenal

Diameter Approximately 200 km; the central cavity is approximately 12 km across

Gravity Normal artificial gravity throughout Kharosai; unstable near damaged projectors and structural seams

Atmosphere None outside; mechanically maintained within Kharosai

Day 24 hours by regulated civic lighting cycle

Year Approximately 326 standard days

Government The **Zakaron Concord**, governed through the Paired Mandate and two clan assemblies

Capital Sairak Axis

Population Approximately 3.1 billion; primarily Vesk and Madrosarai, with established offworld communities

Languages Common, Madrosarai, Vesk

Religions Clan ancestor traditions, martial oaths, Sunlock stewardship, bloodline observances, and imported Settled Systems faiths

Zakaron's airless exterior is covered in industrial armor, cooling infrastructure, and defenses. Exposed rock between the plates bears the damage of the Rupture Wars. The world is much smaller than it was before the Inversion; extensive reconstruction holds the surviving material together.

Ships dock at fortified surface ports. Passengers descend through pressure locks and deep transit shafts before crossing into the city's gravity fields. Approaching Kharosai, local down turns toward the rock behind them. Observation concourses open onto a crowded skyline that curves up the walls and continues overhead.

The Sunlock hangs between the two sides. Across the cavity, upside-down towers rise toward it, with traffic passing between their floors. Haze gathers around the containment machinery and the busiest industrial districts.

THE INVERSION

The **Rupture Wars** began as conflicts among Vesk holds and Madrosarai blood-clans. Coalitions repeatedly formed against whichever power came closest to controlling the planet. Over generations, attacks spread to the infrastructure that kept their populations alive.

Deep weapons destabilized the mantle while orbital bombardment destroyed surface settlements and atmospheric systems. Mining had already weakened much of the crust. The final collapse, remembered as **the Inversion**, broke apart much of Zakaron and left its surviving surface uninhabitable. Refugees withdrew into fortified underground settlements.

Reconstruction consolidated the surviving settlements and salvaged material around a much smaller interior. The population built toward the central cavity, with a contained core remnant providing light and power. The Inversion eventually became the name for both the catastrophe and the reconstruction that followed.

Vesk holds provided most of the heavy engineering and civil defense. Madrosarai blood-clans contributed arcane engineering, medical expertise, and precision manufacturing, including the blood-reactive controls used in sensitive machinery. Cooperation kept the survivors alive, but left many of the institutions responsible for the wars in power.

KHAROSAI

Kharosai names the inhabited interior of Zakaron. The word combines archaic Vesk and Madrosarai terms for a fortified enclosure and a shared interior light. Reconstruction authorities adopted it to recognize both peoples' part in rebuilding.

The city wraps around a roughly spherical cavity about 12 km across. Skyscrapers crowd its inner surface, several reaching hundreds of meters toward the Sunlock. Elevated railways and bridges connect their upper floors. From an open balcony, the curvature is obvious: the skyline continues up either side until it becomes the ceiling.

Most of Kharosai lies behind this visible surface. Inhabited layers extend kilometers into the surrounding rock, with hundreds of levels connected by deep transit shafts. Most residents live in these enclosed districts. Access to a window facing the cavity is expensive.

Kharosai contains thousands of districts, including territorial holds and blood-clan enclaves with their own local governments. Shared transport and utility networks connect them. Residential levels are cramped, and heavy industry occupies separate excavations with dedicated cooling and freight access.

An artificial-gravity lattice directs down toward the shell. Occupants of opposing districts each experience the other side as overhead. Underground levels follow the same local orientation. Poorly synchronized projectors cause shifts in weight and direction, sometimes leaving a street or building briefly weightless.

The major clans maintain local engineering crews, while the Concord coordinates the planetary network. Deliberately disrupting a gravity field is treated as an attack on life-support infrastructure.

Buried ventilation plants maintain the atmosphere and remove industrial heat and contaminants. Enclosed districts have separate pressure controls so that a breach can be isolated. Older residential levels tend to smell of machinery and cooking, especially where ventilation is overdue for repair.

THE SUNLOCK

The **Sunlock** occupies the center of the cavity. It contains a small remnant of Zakaron's original core within magnetic containment and power-generation machinery. Its luminous enclosure is less than a kilometer across; the surrounding rings and service structures extend farther into the cavity.

The installation supplies much of Kharosai's power. Controlled plasma illumination provides its civic day and night cycle, supplemented by local lighting in enclosed districts. Heat exchangers carry waste heat to the exterior radiator fields. Containment failures can interrupt power and gravity, and every major faction insists on retaining access to the machinery.

Residents call the city across the cavity the **Overcity**. The name is relative: someone looking back from those districts would use it for the streets beneath the observer's feet.

The distance between opposing districts is measured in kilometers. On clear cycles, residents can pick out individual towers and follow the lights of overhead trains. Large advertisements face across the cavity. With advanced image stabilization and atmospheric correction, a scope can follow a person along an exposed street or balcony on the opposite side.

Buildings, industrial haze, and the Sunlock itself obstruct that view. Streets directly behind the containment enclosure are hidden from the observer; a position farther along the district may offer a view around it. The crowded skyline leaves frequent gaps in anyone's line of sight.

THE ZAKARON CONCORD

The **Zakaron Concord** grew from reconstruction agreements governing territory, labor, and access to shared infrastructure. Its legislature has two chambers.

The **Assembly of Holds** represents the major Vesk holds, which combine lineage, territorial government, and military or industrial authority. It controls defense spending, public mobilization, heavy infrastructure, and industrial policy, including fleet construction.

The **Conclave of Veils** represents recognized Madrosarai blood-clans. Seats reflect population, territory, inherited agreements, and responsibility for infrastructure, with powerful clans exerting influence over the allocations. The Conclave oversees intelligence and internal security, covert diplomacy, classified research, and regulation of cybernetic and blood-reactive technology.

The Vesk **Kharduun**, or **High Marshal**, commands planetary defense and fleet mobilization, including civil emergency forces. The title's older meaning is “the one who carries the wall.” The Madrosarai **Saivara**, or **First Veil**, directs intelligence, cyberwarfare, classified research, and protection of sensitive infrastructure.

These offices form the **Paired Mandate**. Both must approve declarations of war, major interstellar treaties, planetary emergency powers, unrestricted deployment of classified weapons, and fundamental changes to Sunlock governance.

The assemblies normally dominate policy. During war or an infrastructure crisis, the Kharduun and Saivara can exercise much broader authority. Agreement between them gives the executive considerable control over the planet; a dispute can prevent decisions on essential services.

Zakaron holds a permanent voting seat on the **Settled Systems Code Council**, which drafts, adopts, and amends the **Settled Systems Administrative Code**. The two assemblies jointly appoint its delegation and must both authorize its formal votes. Disagreement can leave Zakaron unable to vote.

HOLDS AND BLOOD-CLANS

Vesk holds and Madrosarai blood-clans remain separate institutions, but both ancestries share Kharosai's workplaces and neighborhoods.

Vesk holds emphasize public duty, military readiness, and responsibility for those under their protection. They disagree over who deserves that protection, who can demand sacrifice, and whether conquest is a legitimate means of establishing order.

Madrosarai blood-clans preserve inherited magical techniques and family archives, alongside covert obligations and control of particular technologies. Their blood has measurable arcane properties that influence its color and the abilities available to a lineage. Those properties also shape expectations about a person's career.

Bloodline	Expected work or role
Gold	Command
Lime	Technical work and cybernetics
Red	Controlled aggression
Stone	Analysis and medicine
Teal	Endurance and service
Umber	Psychic and occult practices

Clans pressure members into these roles through education and obligations to their families. Someone pursuing unrelated work may be accused of wasting an inherited ability. Vesk face similar pressure to enter martial professions, with other ambitions sometimes dismissed as cowardice. Madrosarai seeking heavy military command can face accusations that they want its status without accepting its risks.

THE STAR DREAM AND THE OPEN STARS

The **Star Dream** reached Zakaron after Kharosai was established. Recipients saw other inhabited worlds and the Drift technology that could reach them. Many interpreted the revelation as a mandate to impose order beyond Zakaron, using its existing military strength.

The resulting campaigns are known locally as the **War of the Open Stars** and elsewhere as the **Zakaron Expansion War**. Vesk assault forces seized transport and industrial infrastructure while Madrosarai operatives disrupted enemy command and navigation. Their fleets benefited from advanced equipment and close tactical coordination.

Expansion consumed the Zakaron system's limited erbium deposits. The Concord could keep building warships, but could no longer supply enough refined erbium and Drift components to move and support its fleets. Continued victories extended its supply lines until the campaigns became unsustainable.

THE STILL-DRIVE ACCORDS

The **Still-Drive Accords** take their name from Zakaron's armed ships left without reliable intersystem travel. The settlement preserved the Concord's government, domestic military and industry, and sovereignty over its system. It limited the size and deployment of interstellar fleets, required inspection of imported Drift components, and tied recognized relay access to negotiated erbium allocations.

The Accords took effect at **0:00000000 PES**. Erbium Industries presented the new universal time standard as a means of administering a lasting peace. On Zakaron, that stamp also marks the end of its expansion.

The settlement guaranteed Zakaron its permanent Code Council seat, giving the Concord a say in the laws it was expected to follow. Erbium administers much of the infrastructure used to record, distribute, and enforce the Code. It cannot unilaterally enact new provisions.

Zakaron uses its seat to resist restrictions on military technology and sovereign infrastructure. Its delegates also support harsh identity, security, and emergency laws when those measures benefit the Concord.

Erbium has no chartered authority over Kharosai's domestic industry or public infrastructure, including the gravity network and Sunlock. Corporate representatives work through orbital treaty facilities, licensed trade missions, and Concord-approved intermediaries.

Erbium's leverage comes from control over refined erbium and access to recognized intersystem transport and markets. Zakaron supplies military technology and advanced medical and industrial cybernetics. Both governments fund efforts to replace the products they must obtain from the other.

THE INVERTED ARSENAL

Zakaron produces the Settled Systems' most advanced commercially available cybernetics, alongside restricted military systems. Its exports are durable, modular, and heavily licensed. Classified domestic implants can be several generations ahead of those sold abroad.

Augmentation is common in hazardous infrastructure work. Gravity technicians use vestibular regulators, while exterior crews need protection against radiation and loss of pressure. Blood-keyed interfaces are common among Madrosarai specialists; Vesk emergency personnel often use armor integrated with their bodies.

Employers and clans retain considerable control over these modifications through monitoring and restricted firmware. Military implants can include remote safeties. Access to maintenance and medical care may depend on loyalty, rank, or continued service.

DISTRICTS OF KHAROSAI

Sairak Axis is the capital. The Assembly of Holds and Conclave of Veils occupy separate fortified complexes linked by the Hall of the Paired Mandate. Government towers face the Sunlock from one of the city's most stable gravity regions.

Kheled Foundry Belt houses heavy industry and military manufacturing, including shipyards and implant production. Its elevated freight lines are visible across the cavity. Dedicated cooling systems connect the foundries to the Sunlock exchange network and exterior radiators.

The Black Meridian occupies a deep, reinforced fracture in the shell. Cheap housing and an extensive illegal trade attract clanless residents and undocumented migrants. Unreliable gravity makes restraints standard on furnishings and workshop equipment.

Veilmarket is a Madrosarai commercial and intelligence district known for bloodline clinics and specialized cybernetics. Information brokers and clan operations often occupy larger premises behind ordinary storefronts.

The Ashskin consists of pressure-sealed settlements serving the exterior ports, defenses, and maintenance works. Salvage crews use them as bases for expeditions into pre-Inversion ruins. Beyond the settlements, abandoned military sites and unstable excavations remain dangerous.

HOMELAND AND DIASPORA

More than nine centuries after the beginning of PES, Vesk and Madrosarai live throughout the Settled Systems. Those raised on Zakaron are more likely to have direct clan obligations and military training. Distrust of Erbium and the governments that benefited from Zakaron's defeat remains common.

Offworld families maintain varying degrees of contact through clan traditions and trade. Some identify closely with Zakaron; others have little connection beyond ancestry. Settled Systems institutions still stereotype Vesk as soldiers and Madrosarai as covert operatives, despite the range of lives their descendants now lead.

The Concord claims a political interest in these communities. Many members of the diaspora reject its authority over people who have never lived on Zakaron.